

CHAPTER 14

MEETING KARTHIKEYAN

'Pray to God, he will come.'

17 December 1994. The last few days had passed uneventfully. There was virtually no interrogation; I presumed the CBI officers were documenting the identification parade of IG Raman Srivastava on 12 December, besides crosschecking the information the accused gave. This was the diligent practice of the investigating agency. Soon after getting a statement from the accused, an officer or a constable would visit the place or the person, or summon the person, to verify the accuracy of the information provided. In case of any inconsistency or discrepancy, the accused was questioned further. Clarity, it appeared, was at the core of a CBI investigation.

Now was the time for some more seniors of the agency to take stock of the investigation. On 17 December, such an officer came. He introduced himself as Arun Bhagat, an additional director of CBI. This man, in his fifties, was a symbol of maturity. His questions were sharp, his listening intense and his inferences considered. Bhagat appeared to have studied in detail every available paper in connection with the case, including the IB investigation report.

He was shocked to learn that the IB had adopted third-degree methods during my interrogation. He kept asking other colleagues for details and corroboration, apparently taking pains to understand what had gone wrong with this case, and where. After an hour of questioning, Bhagat left saying